CHHATTISGARH

A FOREST PROTESTS

By Rahul Noronha

A controversial set of coal mining projects in a pristine forest in north Chhattisgarh has been put on hold by the state government amidst a flare-up of the politics surrounding it. Local tribal groups have for months led protests opposing the Parsa East Kente Basan (PEKB) Phase II and the Parsa coal mining projects in Hasdeo Aranya (or Arand, to take the local name) in Ambikapur district, a biodiversity-rich area with dense, mostly saal, forests. The Hasdeo forest is also the catchment area of crucial rivers of the state—including an eponymous one that flows into the Mahanadi. The four mining projects in the region—Parsa, PEKB Phase I and II and Kente Extension—are in various stages of execution; only Phase I is presently being mined.

What precipitated the situation was the commencement of tree-cutting at Parsa and PEKB Phase II sites, with many protesters even clinging to the trees in a bid to save them. Ambikapur Congress MLA and state health minister T.S. Singhdeo visited ground zero at Hariharpur on June 6, throwing in his lot with the protesters and saying that if it comes down to it, "he would take the first bullet" for the cause. This prompted a reconciliatory stand by chief minister Bhupesh Baghel (Singhdeo is his main rival) who said, "Forget a tree, not even a branch will be cut without asking Singhdeo."

HASDEO ARANYA IS A BIODIVERSITY RICH AREA. THE TRIBALS ARE UP IN ARMS AGAINST THE MINING PROJECTS

So has the matter been resolved? Not really, but let's go back to the beginning. A series of coal mining blocks were allocated in Chhattisgarh starting in 2007. But in 2009, the Union ministry of environment and forests (MoEFCC) identified certain 'No Go' areas where works detrimental to the environment were not to be taken up. Parsa, PEKB Phase I and Phase II are all within the No Go areas. Still, in 2011, forest clearance was accorded to PEKB and work commenced at Phase I. In 2014, the NGT stayed mining at Phase I in response to a petition but the stay didn't last long. The matter eventually reached the Supreme Court, which ordered a study—it was not taken up till 2019. Studies were eventually conducted



IN SOLIDARITY Minister T.S. Singhdeo with protesters at Hasdeo Aranya, Jun. 6